could wait.

Bairam Khan disagreed. Not only should Akbar stay, he must march upon Delhi at once; they might still surprise Hemu with speed if not overwhelm him with numbers. The choice was clear: Did Akbar wish to be emperor of Hindustan, or would he retreat to the comforts of Kabul and remain a provincial padishah?

It's equally possible that there was no such choice at all – that Bairam Khan was more interested in asserting his own authority than in building Akbar's future. It could be, as Abul Fazl suggests, that Bairam Khan's deputy, Pir Muhammad, ran away from Delhi to demoralize Tardi Beg's troops and put him in exactly this embarrassed situation: a veteran commander having to explain himself to a fourteen-year-old.

Tardi Beg had not challenged the ambitious regent so far, and Bairam Khan deferred to the older soldier, calling him *toqan*, 'elder brother'[26] – but there was little family feeling between the two. Bairam was a Persianized Turk, his clan historically associated with the descendants of Timur. Tardi Beg was a Chagatai, proud of his Mongol lineage, and imagining himself, as Ferishta once wrote of Chagatai chiefs generally, 'at least equal to [the legendary Persian kings] Keikobad and Keikaoos'. One was a talented general, relatively young, a tactician and diplomat who had stuck by the Mughals since he was sixteen; the other a grizzled nobleman with a keen interest in the health of his treasury, who would well remember how Humayun once ran after him, begging for his loyalty. Finally, Bairam was Shia and Tardi Beg was Sunni. Little wonder, then, if both were looking for ways 'to ruin one another'.[27]

Tardi Beg's retreat from Delhi gave Bairam a perfect opportunity to strike. He did not waste it.

Akbar was out hunting. The boy had prevented Abul Ma'ali's execution and Bairam was not inclined to take such a chance again. Quickly, as Akbar rode through Sirhind with his sparrowhawks, his regent sent a friendly message to Tardi 'toqan', inviting him to his tent. No one knows what they talked about. Perhaps Bairam let the commander reinvigorate himself with old war tales. Perhaps he let him imagine that Bairam sought his advice; that he, too, was anxious to return to his fort in Qandahar. They might even have had an avuncular conversation about Akbar and the boy's uncertain